Week 3 | Web Scraping Made Me See the Internet as a Messy Interface

Reflection

So this week I tried web scraping for the first time, and it did not go well. I wanted to scrape a list of local events from a community website. I watched the LinkedIn Learning video and thought, okay, this looks simple: use Python with BeautifulSoup, find the right HTML tags, and pull out the data. I wrote a short script to grab all the `<div class="event">` elements. But when I ran it, I got almost nothing. The page looked fine in my browser, but the HTML my script received was different. Some events were loaded only after clicking "load more", and the class names were inconsistent. I spent ages trying to fix it, and in the end I only got half the data. That was frustrating, but it taught me something important: the web is not a clean database. It is a messy interface built for humans, not for machines.

This connects directly to Venturini and Rogers (2025) in Chapter 6, "Scraping Documents and Interfaces." They argue that scraping is not just a technical skill; it requires understanding the interface as a constructed object. My experience proved that. The website was designed for people to browse, not for me to extract data from. The HTML structure was inconsistent, and the dynamic loading meant the "real" data was hidden behind JavaScript. So

scraping forced me to deconstruct the page, just like we learned in Week 2. I had to open the browser's inspect tool and look at the network tab to find where the data was actually coming from. That was a moment of realisation: the Internet is not a flat surface of information. It is layers of code, interfaces, and decisions.

Venturini and Rogers also discuss the legal and ethical challenges of scraping. That made me think about my own project. I was scraping a public community website, but I never asked permission. Tiidenberg's (2018) optional chapter on ethics in digital research reminded me that even public data can be sensitive, and consent and anonymity are not automatic. I did not use the data for anything serious, but if I did, I would need to think about who owns that information and whether scraping it is fair. This challenged my understanding of the Internet. I used to think of it as a place where information is just "there" and free to take. Now I see it as a space of constructed interfaces, and scraping is a way of asking questions about those constructions.

Finally, this week also asked me to reflect on setting up my portfolio website. Building my own site made me realise how easy it is to make HTML that looks fine to humans but is messy for machines. My navigation and sections were simple, but I did not use consistent class names or semantic tags. If someone tried to scrape my site, they would have a hard time. That made me think: would I want my site to be scraped? Probably not without permission. So web

scraping did not just teach me a technical method. It made me more aware of the Internet as something built, contestable, and full of ethical decisions. And that is exactly what this week was about.